designed to deter additional Chinese incursions by “installing posts and ensuring patrolling” at the boundary. Contrary to Indian expectations, China had responded, resuming its forward patrols in the western sector. Throughout the summer a series of border clashes, settlement offers, rejections, and counteroffers heightened the tension.[226]

There was little expectation in the US of a full-scale war. An intelligence estimate that summer indicated that the Indian forward policy would lead to some clashes, but “odds are against any major military escalation.”[227] In early August, the State Department expected the stalemate to continue, emphasizing that there were “no indications that either side wishes to start up full-scale fighting at present.” Galbraith conveyed Nehru’s concern about “the number of men up in the mountains ‘who wonder who is going to shoot first.’” The prime minister, nevertheless, expected that further talks in September, while unlikely to bear fruit, might “calm” the situation.[228]

A major reason why Nehru thought that China would not attack India was that he believed this would lead to others getting involved and potentially to a world war—an argument he repeated to the press, his party, and parliament. One of those “others” was Moscow. The Australian high commissioner in Delhi believed Nehru saw the Soviet Union as “the best insurance” against Chinese overreaction.[229] The American intelligence community assessed that the most important Indian interest vis-à-vis Moscow had indeed become its ability to help (or hurt) India on the China question.[230]

Just as Indian officials had kept an eye on Sino-Soviet relations, they had also followed Sino-US developments. In the later years of the Eisenhower administration, Indian officials had detected a growing sense in the US that isolating China was unrealistic and perhaps even dangerous. Subsequently, given increasing Sino-Soviet differences, there was speculation at the Indian embassy in Washington that the Kennedy administration might reach out to China. Officials thought a Sino-US rapprochement would benefit India since it could lead to more restrained Chinese behavior. Regardless, the prevailing sense in India had been that any major change was unlikely because of Chinese actions, domestic opposition in the US, and Jiang’s sentiments.[231] Thus they expected the US to continue to back India vis-à-vis China—and hoped that support would deter Beijing.